

out if we can, we should also put extensive thought into understanding if we should.

Artificial Presence

Virtual reality enables you to perceive a completely virtual or different reality than your current physical reality, as if you are actually present there and interacting. One of the basic tenets of virtual reality is telepresence, which essentially means a sense of being elsewhere, created by virtual reality technology. This idea has been around for a while in its basic form and has helped businesses a lot by reducing communication barriers while avoiding actual travel costs as well. What is interesting is the current state it is in, and where it is headed.

Dexterous Observational Roving Automaton, or DORA, is a fully telepresence enabled robot designed for navigation and exploration of remote locations as if you are actually there. The robot supports six degrees of freedom movements and mimics the user's actions with near-zero latency. Needless to say, the device puts to use stereoscopic 3D visuals and 3D audio to maintain immersion and it can be controlled wirelessly from anywhere in the world. If you want to see its accuracy for yourself, check out their demo at <http://dgit.in/DORAplatform>.

The DORA robot is still in development and it will be some time before it is actually used to its full potential in fields like military, rescue ops, or even corporate businesses. But that doesn't mean that the technology and what it can achieve, is still way over the horizon. For the iPhone 6s launched to the public on September 25th, Apple's Palo Alto store had the usual line of people queuing up to purchase Apple's latest Smartphone. Why are we saying this? Because the line wasn't entirely made up of humans, or organic beings for that matter. Briana Lempesis was controlling a telepresence robot to stand in line since the previous day to get her iPhone 6s.

Suitable technologies, the company that makes the Beam telepresence robot, had undertaken this as a way of promoting their product and it did garner a lot of attention at the venue, with a number of reporters interviewing Briana via the robot. Also, in spite of being a promotional, there was no hindrance in Briana's purchase of the Smartphone. The money had to be placed in a rear compartment and a store employee had to be instructed on taking it out, and then they had to place the phone in a plastic bag which was hung on a hook on the robots body. The last bit is obviously prone to theft but it is hardly something that can't be worked around.